

S02-04 - After the Ambush

Player text

The brush goes still. Whatever you did, it is done. The horses breathe hard. The road smells like wet thorn, churned mud, and adrenaline fading too slowly. Among what was dropped, you see gear that does not look like bandit scrap: stamped buckles, route tags, and filed-off inventory marks from the same kind of system that hired you.

Public objective

Decide what to do with what just happened and get the package moving again.

Raw source

- Id: S02-04
- Type: scene
- Sectionid: ACT-TWO
- Sectiontitle: Act Two: Cargo Reclaimers
- Title: After the Ambush
- Shorttitle: Aftermath
- Order: 304
- Playersafe: True
- Completioneligible: True
- Image: assets/scenes/S02-04-after-the-ambush.png
- Alt: After the Ambush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers.
- Caption: After the fight, the module asks what victory cost and what the party learned.
- Mood: Cargo Reclaimers
- Gmgoal: Turn the outcome of the ambush into consequence, truth, and the next route toward the village.
- Publicobjective: Decide what to do with what just happened and get the package moving again.
- Readaloud: The brush goes still. Whatever you did, it is done. The horses breathe hard. The road smells like wet thorn, churned mud, and adrenaline fading too slowly. Among what was dropped, you see gear that does not look like bandit scrap: stamped buckles, route tags, and filed-off inventory marks from the same kind of system that hired you.
- Gmnotes: Mercy route: leader or survivors talk. Combat route: gear and effects talk. Either route should leave the party asking who benefits from a dangerous forest.
- Gmscript: Say: "The fight is over. The outcome matters now." If mercy or negotiation opened trust, say: "Up close, these people look less like bandits and more like former workers who have been sleeping rough and losing for a long time." If the party killed or routed them, say: "The gear tells the story the survivors cannot: company issue, filed off and reused." If players ask for the truth, use Presence or Knowledge 14, or mercy already earned, to reveal: "They were company or preserve workers who say the danger reports were manufactured to sell protection and discard the people who noticed."

- Gmreadaloud: The brush goes still. Whatever you did, it is done. Among what was dropped, you see gear that does not look like bandit scrap: stamped buckles, route tags, and filed-off inventory marks. The road smells like wet thorn, churned mud, and adrenaline fading too slowly.
- Gmchecklist: Read `bramble_outcome` before choosing variant tone. Set `bramble_truth_learned` only if mercy/parley, survivor dialogue, or Presence/Knowledge 14 earns it. Unlock location maps only for spared, negotiated, captured-with-care, or escaped-with-contact routes. Give a thread, not the whole campaign explanation.
- Gmprivate: The workers' claim is the first load-bearing truth thread, but the driver-killer canon flag remains unresolved. Do not mention Keystone Asset in player-facing aftermath. If players pursue the communities, use the two location maps as optional discovery, not mandatory plot.
- Playertakeaway: You do not have the whole picture, but you have seen enough to question who benefits from a dangerous forest.
- Storytakeaway: The attackers were tied to the same company world that hired the party; the forest's danger story no longer matches the evidence.
- Mechanictakeaway: The mechanic here is consequence: `bramble_outcome` and `bramble_truth_learned` decide what doors open next.
- Rollcards: `s02-04-question-a-spared-reclaimer` S02-04 Question a spared reclaimer Question a spared reclaimer Presence Knowledge Presence Knowledge 12 Presence keeps them talking; Knowledge asks the right claim question. A living prisoner becomes a person or a problem. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. A living prisoner becomes a person or a problem. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets the core result, but it costs...
- Entityids: `bramble-union-loot` `kett-alderhook` `vela-bramblewick` `rye-underbough` `brannic-mossvein` `bramble-ward-scrap-charm-cluster` `claimrunner-serrated-blade` `bramble-union-stoneweave` `vial-of-briarpowder` `bramble-union-reclaimer-personal-effects` `garrick-reed` `bramble-union-claimrunner` `goldspire-territories` `route-assurance-contract` `khari-nix` `sealed-keystone-crate` `damage-armor` `hush`
- Entities: `bramble-union-loot` Bramble Union Loot item Item / Asset `assets/icons/item.png` `assets/entities/bramble-union-loot.png` BRAM-bul YOO-nyun Loot Personal effects and evidence carried by Bramble Union members. Loot and clue table Personal effects and evidence carried by Bramble Union members.; use Bramble Union Loot as a concrete table object with texture, ownership, and a reason it matters now. Give players a tangible handle on Bramble Union, Bramble Union Ambusher, Bramble Union Claimrunner, whether they inspect, carry, return, trade, or refuse it. Personal effects and evidence carried by Bramble Union members. `kett-alderhook` Kett Alderhook npc NPC / Ally `assets/icons/npc.png` `assets/npc-images/kett-alderhook/portrait_base.png` KET AWL-der-hook A desperate cargo runner who believes

the road stole from his people first. The one who has to decide whether tonight's robbery becomes tonight's massacre. Kett Alderhook a desperate field leader trying to seize leverage from the carriage Carries the whole camp's survival like a debt he co-signed. Hard-jawed in front of the scouts, unsure the moment they look away. Believes the road stole from his people first, and is terrified of becoming the...

- Itemids: bramble-union-stoneweave vial-of-briarpowder bramble-ward-scrap-charm-cluster claimrunner-serrated-blade
- Clueids: route-assurance-contracttm reclaimer-personal-effects old-contract-tags the-interrogation-answer the-painted-joy
- Statecontrols: bramble_outcome Bramble outcome select unresolved killed captured spared negotiated escaped Shapes the aftermath variant and map access.
bramble_truth_learned Bramble truth learned checkbox Set only after mercy/parley, survivor trust, or Presence/Knowledge 14. locationMapsUnlocked Location maps unlocked checkbox Use for mercy, negotiated, spared, or trusted survivor routes.
- Mechanicsids: action-roll presence knowledge short-rest stress disposition-track gm-moves hope fear
- Playerquestions: What detail in After the Ambush tells you the official story is incomplete? Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it? What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?
- Relationshipprompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownershipprompt: Name one detail in After the Ambush that belongs to your character's point of view.
- Fearsponds: Spend Fear to reveal omitted risk, split attention, or put a human cost in front of the contract. Close the ambush net or put a PC between cargo and a frightened reclaimer. Reveal a personal effect that makes victory emotionally complicated.
- Choicesconsequences: Question survivors with care Presence 14 or earned mercy reveals the worker-displacement thread. Location maps can open and Act 3 starts with sharper questions. Threat interrogation may get facts but close trust. Search dropped gear Knowledge 14 reads company issue and filed inventory marks. Truth is thinner without survivors but still points at the company story cracking. Ignoring gear leaves bramble_truth_learned false. Tend the wounded or bury the dead Mercy becomes visible to any survivor. A guide, safe route, or future ally can become available. Looting first makes later trust harder.
- Lootclues: Personal effects Route sketch Old Goldspire seal Bramble Union
Stoneweave: A garment of thousands of tiny polished stones moves like cloth and turns thorns like armor. Every fitted piece looks cut by hands that loved the work.
Vial of Briarpowder: A small stoppered vial holds fine grey-green thorn powder that seems to drink the light. A blade edge near it looks sharper and hungrier. Bramble
Ward-Scrap Charm Cluster: A knot of blue ward shards, twine, and tiny salvage tags clacks softly at a Bramblefolk belt. It looks illegal only because it looks useful.
- Handoutids: Personal effects Earned seed
- Sourcescenelug: S02-04-after-the-ambush
- Sourcefiles: dist/Act2_Upgrade_Packet/ACT2_SCENE_UPGRADES.md
dist/Act2_Upgrade_Packet/ACT2_PER_CHARACTER.md
- References: Ambush outcome #S02-03 Hidden villages if unlocked #MAP-LOC-bramble-union-villages Living thorn refuge if unlocked #MAP-LOC-the-wandering-briar

- Storyscope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. The reclaimers target the cargo and manifest, not purses, and avoid killing when possible. REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Their gear includes salvaged, repainted Grail/Kazrak kit: ex-workers, not feral bandits. REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Knowledge Medium 15 to name the issue "That stone belongs in the ground." "You do not know what you are carrying." ADD EARNED A spared/captured reclaimer says monster attacks spiked when protection contracts went on sale. ADD EARNED Presence Medium 15; requires mercy or capture A spared/captured reclaimer says monster attacks spiked when protection contracts went on sale. ADD EARNED Presence Medium 15; requires mercy or capture Instinct: spot ambush. Presence: parley/interrogate. Knowledge: recognize corporate-issue gear. ACT2 Act 2: Bramble ambush 90 0:55 to 1:30 1:30 first combat and possible interrogation Abstract the fight via a Group Action roll; keep one captured reclaimer...
- Livetools: scene MAP-LOC-goldspire-territories
- Percharacterlayer: marlowe-fairwind Marlowe Fairwind Cargo implications Knowledge 14 Connects the worker-displacement story to the package question without resolving what the package is. Can ask what a sealed delivery means if the danger around the route was manufactured. Marlowe, their story and your cargo are starting to rhyme. Want to follow that thought? garrick-reed Garrick Reed Ex-security recognition Knows company-issue kit on sight and recognizes the pattern of discarding people who noticed too much. Presence 14 A survivor trusts him faster, one ex-company hand to another. Can get the fullest version of the truth thread on offer. Garrick, you have seen the company do this to its own. She may talk to you. Want to hear it? varian-soto Varian Soto Wounded survivors Smells which wounded people can still be helped and who is fading fast. Can tend the wounded; mercy can open the location-map path. Varian, some of them will live if you help. Want to? It might open a door. barnacle Barnacle Desperate survivor rapport Recognizes cornered-survivor behavior without needing to judge it first. Can broker safe passage or an information exchange with survivors. Barnacle, you know what cornered looks like...
- Takeawayhelp: Player takeaway You do not have the whole picture, but you have seen enough to question who benefits from a dangerous forest. "You do not know the whole truth. You know enough to stop trusting the easy version." "You can question survivors, tend the wounded, search dropped gear, bury the dead, or get the package moving with new questions in your pocket." Give players permission to move on without solving everything. The takeaway is suspicion with evidence, not a lore dump. gm-moves presence knowledge Story takeaway The attackers were tied to the same company world that hired the party; the forest's danger story no longer matches the evidence. "These people were not outside the system. They were used by it, discarded by it, or armed from its leftovers." "Mercy or Presence/Knowledge 14 can reveal the worker-displacement thread: they say danger reports were manufactured to sell protection and silence people who noticed." Keep the reveal as a thread. Do not settle the driver-killer canon flag or the whole ward economy yet. gm-moves presence knowledge Mechanic takeaway The mechanic here is consequence: bramble_outcome and bramble_truth_learned decide what doors open next. "How this..."
- Playerbeats: S02-04-quiet-after The quiet after The quiet after assets/scenes/S02-04-after-the-ambush.png After the Ambush scene art for Cargo

Reclaimers. The ambush ends, and the road feels too quiet for a victory cheer. The ambush ends, and the road feels too quiet for a victory cheer. The ambush ends, and the road feels too quiet for a victory cheer. text-first S02-04-who-they-were Who they were Company marks in the gear assets/scenes/S02-04-after-the-ambush.png After the Ambush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. Stamped buckles, route tags, and filed-off inventory marks show these people were tied to the same company world that hired you. Stamped buckles, route tags, and filed-off inventory marks show these people were tied to the same company world that hired you. Stamped buckles, route tags, and filed-off inventory marks show these people were tied to the same company world that hired you. text-first S02-04-thread The thread The first truth thread assets/scenes/S02-04-after-the-ambush.png After the Ambush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. The story you were hired into no longer matches the evidence on the road. The story you were hired into no longer matches the evidence on the road. The...

- Gmbeats: S02-04-quiet-after The quiet after The quiet after Say: "The fight is over, but the road does not feel solved. What is the first thing your character does when the adrenaline drops?" The ambush ends, and the road feels too quiet for a victory cheer. Aftermath is a playable scene, not a fade-out. Consequence begins when the table names what they do after danger. Players can choose care, search, questions, or movement. Player takeaway Players can choose care, search, questions, or movement. "The fight is over, but the road does not feel solved. What is the first thing your character does when the adrenaline drops?" "The playable facts are: The ambush ends, and the road feels too quiet for a victory cheer." Use this beat to point the table at one immediate choice. The player-facing fact is: The ambush ends, and the road feels too quiet for a victory cheer. gm-moves table-spotlight Story takeaway Aftermath is a playable scene, not a fade-out. "The fight is over, but the road does not feel solved. What is the first thing your character does when the adrenaline drops?" "The story fact you can trust is: Aftermath is a playable scene, not a fade-out." This beat changes the fiction...
- Beatautoplayeligible: True
- Beatautoplaydefault: False
- Beatautoplayintervalms: 9000
- Playersafeprojection: S02-04 scene After the Ambush assets/scenes/S02-04-after-the-ambush.png After the Ambush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. After the fight, the module asks what victory cost and what the party learned. Cargo Reclaimers Decide what to do with what just happened and get the package moving again. The brush goes still. Whatever you did, it is done. The horses breathe hard. The road smells like wet thorn, churned mud, and adrenaline fading too slowly. Among what was dropped, you see gear that does not look like bandit scrap: stamped buckles, route tags, and filed-off inventory marks from the same kind of system that hired you. S02-04-quiet-after The quiet after The quiet after assets/scenes/S02-04-after-the-ambush.png After the Ambush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. The ambush ends, and the road feels too quiet for a victory cheer. The ambush ends, and the road feels too quiet for a victory cheer. The ambush ends, and the road feels too quiet for a victory cheer. text-first S02-04-who-they-were Who they were Company marks in the gear assets/scenes/S02-04-after-the-ambush.png After the Ambush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. Stamped buckles, route tags, and filed-off inventory marks show...
- Companionmapids: MAP-LOC-goldspire-territories

- Slidenumber: 38
- Totalslides: 110
- Spotlights: SPOT-M-CONSEQUENCE consequence-chain consequence-chain M23 S02-04 med
mandatory beat:resolution Carry the Choice Forward Earlier mercy, trust, and truth
choices must matter later. Name the consequence the table just created. Record the
state change while the scene is fresh. Bring it back later as help, suspicion, lost
trust, a warning, or a changed route. Consequence chain wiki/mechanic/consequence-
chain consequences-and-hints True Stop choices from evaporating after the scene
ends. mechanic defer-if-clock-critical True True
- Spotlightsummary: 1

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